

Start Here: Run StoryDogs in 20 Minutes

A ready-to-use plan for teachers and librarians • Grades K–6

Aim for a connected seven-step outline. A sentence or spoken idea at each step is enough to start. You don't need storytelling training or a room full of stuffed dogs.

Before you begin: Open MarkCheverton.com/story-dogs or use paper and the cheat sheet. Have a way to record ideas. The website has two questions per stage; keep answers brief for this first round.

Choose a format

Whole class: Project the activity and record one shared story. Hear two suggestions, choose one together, and move on.

Pairs: Partners tell ideas aloud, agree on one story, and alternate typing or writing at each step.

Independent: Students plan their own stories. Offer a brief partner chat whenever an idea stalls. Younger children can draw or dictate while an adult acts as scribe. Read their words back and let them decide what stays.

Time	Stage	What to say or do
0–2 min	Get ready	"We're making a plan. Ideas can change." Choose the format and explain that one short idea per step is enough.
2–5 min	WHO? LIFE / WANT	"Who are we following? What is a normal day like? What do they want?" Record a character, routine, and wish.
5–7 min	UH-OH!	"What changes that ordinary day?" Choose an event that matters to this character.
7–10 min	TROUBLE	"Because that happened, what problem do they face? What do they try?" Keep the events connected.
10–13 min	WORSE!	"How does that problem get harder? Why does it matter?" Bigger feelings can be enough.
13–16 min	CLIMAX	"What does the character choose to do at the biggest moment?" Let their action affect the outcome.
16–18 min	CHANGE	"What do they do or understand differently now?" Compare the ending with the beginning.
18–20 min	Read and keep	Read the outline aloud. Ask, "Does each problem follow from what came before?" Save, copy, download, or print it.

When the class gets stuck

Give 20 seconds to sketch or talk. Offer one matching prompt card, then let students choose. Ask "What could happen because of that?" If time runs out, leave a gap and return later. Save a copy before clearing a shared computer. That means having kids copy their plot outline and paste it into a google doc, so they don't lose their ideas.